

Overcoming Obstacles Worksheet



Obstacles often get in the way when you are trying to start exercising more regularly. Three strategies to help reduce the obstacles you might be facing are identified here. At the bottom, choose the three biggest obstacles to maintaining an exercise program and identify which strategies are the best ways for you to overcome these obstacles.

1. If you have not done so already, create a list of benefits of regular physical activity. As you increase your list of benefits, the drawbacks may seem less important.
2. Usually the drawbacks (cons) of exercise are more like hassles than real issues. Compare them to the sometimes severe consequences of not exercising regularly.
 - a. How does the cost of exercise (e.g., gym gear, taking a class) compare to the risk of diabetes or heart disease?
 - b. How does the time it takes to exercise compare to the time you might be adding to your life by exercising?
 - c. How does the temporary discomfort of starting to exercise compare to the chance of building up flexibility, strength, and endurance?
3. Try to refute the cons of exercising by replacing them with alternatives or challenges. Some examples:
 - a. When I am bored and tired of riding the stationary bike or running on a treadmill, I can watch TV or read an exciting book.
 - b. If I cannot find a 30-minute block of time to exercise, perhaps I can find three 10-minute blocks during the day.
 - c. If I am embarrassed to exercise in front of others, I can exercise at home, go to a class for beginners, or go to the gym when it is not crowded.

Your Three Biggest Obstacles	Three Practical Alternatives

Source: Adapted from ACSM Behavioral Aspects of Physical Activity and Exercise, p. 113.